

This hamster.



THE FACTS

One sheet each

Name _____

Species _____

Male / female _____ Colour _____

Born or about _____ Came home _____

Where from, and what they were kept in _____

Anything known about before _____

A Syrian lives alone. That part is not negotiable.

Syrians turn on a cage mate somewhere around eight weeks old, and the fight is usually found in the morning. Chinese are solitary too. Dwarf species are sometimes kept in same-sex pairs from the same litter, in a very large cage with two of everything — and even then it can end, quickly, at any age. One hamster per cage is the version that always works.

HOW LONG WE HAVE THEM

SPECIES	KEPT	YEARS
Syrian	Alone, always	2–3
Chinese	Alone	2–3
Roborovski	Pairs sometimes	3
Winter White	Pairs sometimes	1½–2
Campbell's	Pairs sometimes	1½–2

Ours _____ Old at about _____

A hamster of eighteen months is an old animal. Page 9 is where that gets written down rather than noticed too late.

WHAT THEY ARE LIKE

What a stranger would need

When they get up _____

When they go quiet _____

Where they sleep, and their nest _____

Where they have hoarded _____

How they are picked up _____

What makes them jumpy _____

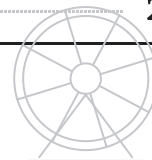
Have they bitten, and what happened _____

THINGS THEY ALREADY DO THAT ARE THEIRS

ESCAPING

Assume it will happen once

- ☐ Door and lid checked every night, by one named person
- ☐ Gaps under doors blocked in the room they are in
- ☐ A bucket, a ramp and some seed is how they are caught
- ☐ Flour on the floor overnight shows you the room



Numbers, and when to use them.

Date _____

Find the vet before you need one

Plenty of practices will happily register a hamster and have not treated one in years. Ask the question today, on the telephone, in these words: **do you have a vet who sees small exotics, and are they in at weekends?** Write down whoever says yes, because a hamster that is unwell in the evening does not have until Monday.

THE PRACTICE

Vet who sees exotics _____

Daytime number _____

Address _____

OUT OF HOURS — USUALLY SOMEWHERE ELSE

Who covers nights _____

Number _____

Address, and how long it takes _____

ALSO WORTH HAVING

Who drives, if it is the evening _____

Insurance, if any _____

Whoever has a spare key _____

THE CARRY BOX, MADE UP IN ADVANCE

☐ A small solid box with a lid and air holes

☐ A handful of their own bedding, so it smells right

☐ A slice of cucumber instead of a water bottle

☐ Kept warm on the way, never on a cold car seat

PHONE NOW, DO NOT WAIT UNTIL MORNING

☐ Watery diarrhoea and a wet, dirty bottom, hunched and not moving — wet tail, and in a young Syrian it can kill in a day or two

☐ Cold, stiff and seemingly dead in a cold room — this can be torpor. Warm the room slowly, warm them in your hands, and phone

☐ Breathing with effort, clicking or squeaking, or a wet nose and eyes

☐ Not eating, not drinking, and nothing new in the hoard for a day

☐ Drooling, a wet chin, or eating dropped food — the front teeth may be overgrown

☐ A bulging or closed eye, or a pouch that will not empty — never pull at a pouch

☐ A leg not being used after a fall, or caught in a wheel or bars

☐ Any lump that is new, or bleeding from anywhere

This list is the short version of what vets who see small animals ask people to come in for. It is not a diagnosis and it is not complete. A hamster hides being unwell until it is very unwell, so a hamster that seems wrong to you is a good enough reason to phone.

WEIGHT NOW, AND WHAT IT WAS

Now _____ grams, on kitchen scales

A month ago _____

The home, measured.



Date _____

MEASURE WHAT YOU ACTUALLY HAVE

Ours, in centimetres
WHAT, AND THE FIGURE TO AIM AT OURS OK

Unbroken floor area

100 × 50 cm is what most keepers work to

☐

Bar spacing, if barred

1 cm or less, or a dwarf will get out

☐

Bedding depth, deepest corner

25–40 cm, so they can dig a burrow

☐

Wheel diameter

Syrian 28 cm+, dwarf 20 cm+, solid surface

☐

Sand bath dish

Play or chinchilla sand — never dust, never water

☐

Hides

At least two, and one with more than one room

☐

Chews and gnawing wood

The front teeth never stop growing

☐

Water

Bottle and a shallow dish; checked every day

☐

Room temperature

18–24°C, out of sun and draughts

☐

Measure the floor, not the box

Cage sizes on the shelf are measured generously and count shelves, tubes and lids as space. A hamster uses the floor: one unbroken rectangle it can run and dig in. Take a tape to the inside of the base, write the number above, and if it is short, a large flat-packed storage box with a mesh lid costs less than a cage and is usually bigger.

WHERE THE CAGE IS

Room

☐ Out of direct sun and away from a radiator

☐ Not in a draught, and not on the floor

☐ Not on or beside a television or speaker

☐ Somewhere a night-time noise will not wake the house

Bedding: deep, plain, and never fluffy

Paper-based bedding or unscented aspen, deep enough in at least one corner to hold a burrow that does not fall in. Not pine or cedar shavings. And **never** the fluffy cotton-wool bedding sold beside them: it wraps around legs, and it does not pass through a hamster that swallows it.

WHAT WE USE

Bedding

Nesting material

Sand

Bought from

THE WHEEL

Measured across, inside

☐ Solid running surface, no bars and no mesh

☐ Their back stays flat when they run, not curved

☐ Quiet enough that nobody unplugs it at midnight

☐ Wiped weekly — it is where the wee ends up

CHANGED OR ADDED, AND WHEN

WHAT CHANGED	WHEN

The week.



Date _____

EVERY DAY

W water · F food · S spot · E eyes on

DAY	W	F	S	E	ANYTHING TO NOTE
-----	---	---	---	---	------------------

Mon	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Tue	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Wed	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Thu	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Fri	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Sat	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Sun	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____

WHAT THOSE FOUR MEAN

- ☐ Water: bottle actually runs when you tap it
- ☐ Food: fresh food from yesterday taken out
- ☐ Spot: the wet corner lifted out and replaced
- ☐ Eyes on: seen awake and moving, not just a lump of bedding

ONCE A WEEK

- ☐ Wheel wiped, sand sieved or changed
- ☐ Hoard checked and anything fresh taken out
- ☐ Weighed, in grams, and written on page 5
- ☐ Looked over properly — page 7

Do not clean it all at once

A cage stripped and scrubbed is a hamster whose whole map of the world has been deleted, and that shows up as bar chewing, hoarding in a panic, or a bite. Change a part of the bedding at a time, put a handful of the old back in, and leave the nest alone unless it is wet. Hot water and a little unscented soap; no disinfectant smell.

ONCE A MONTH, OR WHEN IT NEEDS IT

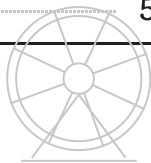
- ☐ Part of the bedding changed, some of the old kept back
- ☐ Bottle taken apart and the spout checked
- ☐ Cage wiped, no strong cleaners
- ☐ Chews looked at and replaced

WHO DOES WHAT

JOB	WHOSE
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

WHAT WE NOTICED THIS MONTH

Food, and the hoard.



Date _____

WHAT THEY EAT

A tablespoon of mix is a day

WHATHOW MUCHWHEN

Scatter it, do not put it in a bowl

Throwing the day’s mix across the bedding turns dinner into an hour of foraging, which is most of the enrichment a hamster needs and costs nothing. A bowl is eaten in four minutes and the rest of the night is a wheel. Keep a bowl for the fresh food, which comes out again the next day.

FRESH, SMALL AND OFTEN

A slice, not a plateful

NEVER

Citrus, onion, garlic	Too acidic, or toxic outright
Chocolate and sweets	As bad here as in any other animal
Sticky or sugary treats	Yoghurt drops, honey sticks — pouches
Almonds, apple pips	Bitter almonds and pips carry cyanide
Raw beans, raw potato	Both are toxic uncooked
Anything from the table	Salt and fat, in an animal this small

THE HOARD

Checked weekly, not emptied

- ☐ Fresh food taken out before it turns
- ☐ The dry hoard left where it is — it is theirs
- ☐ A hoard that stops growing is worth a note

WEIGHT, IN GRAMS

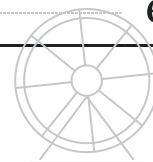
Same scales, same day

MONTHGRAMSWHAT ELSE YOU NOTICED

January		
February		
March		
April		
May		
June		
July		
August		
September		
October		
November		
December		

A kitchen scale and a small bowl will do it: put the bowl on, zero it, and let them potter about in it for a moment. On an animal weighing forty or a hundred and fifty grams, a tenth of the body gone is a fortnight of quiet weight loss and it is very hard to see through fur — so weigh weekly the moment anything looks off, and take the numbers with you.

The night.



Date _____

Never wake a hamster to hold it

Everything good with a hamster happens on their clock. They surface in the evening, run further in a night than you would walk in a day, and a hand that arrives at two in the afternoon is a predator in a dream. Wait for them to come out, let them hear you first, and let them come to the hand rather than the other way round.

Why there is no ball on this list

A hamster in a plastic ball cannot see where it is going, cannot stop, cannot smell anything useful and has small feet next to a lot of ventilation slots. Most people who keep hamsters have quietly stopped using them. A taped-off playpen on the floor, with hides and cardboard and you sitting in it, does the same job and they can leave.

WHEN THIS HAMSTER IS ACTUALLY UP

Out at _____ Back in at _____

Busiest hour _____

WHAT THEY DO WITH THE NIGHT

What this one uses

- ☐ The wheel
- ☐ Digging, once the bedding is deep enough
- ☐ Foraging for scattered food
- ☐ Cardboard, tubes and boxes to destroy
- ☐ Climbing, low down and over something soft
- ☐ The sand bath

ROTATED, NOT ADDED TO

Cheap, and changed often

THE PLAYPEN

Never out of sight, not even once

- ☐ Sides taller than they can climb or jump
- ☐ Nothing they can get behind or under
- ☐ On the floor, so there is nowhere to fall from
- ☐ Counted back in before you walk away

CHEWING THE BARS, OR PACING

What it usually means

- ☐ Not enough floor, or not enough bedding to dig in
- ☐ A wheel too small, or no wheel at all
- ☐ Nothing to forage for, food in a bowl
- ☐ Woken during the day, again

WHAT WE TRIED, AND WHETHER IT HELPED

In your hands.



Date _____

THE WEEKLY LOOK-OVER

Mostly by looking

WHAT TO LOOK FOR	DONE	NOTICED
Eyes Both open, clear, not sticky	☐	_____
Nose and breathing Dry, quiet, no clicking	☐	_____
Front teeth Even, not overlong, chin dry	☐	_____
Pouches Empty at some point — never pull	☐	_____
Bottom Dry and clean, bedding not stuck	☐	_____
Feet and nails No sores, nails not curling	☐	_____
Coat No bald patches, no scurf or wetness	☐	_____
Under the hands Slowly, for lumps	☐	_____

Most of this is done with your eyes while they are busy with a sunflower seed. Only the last one needs hands, and it is worth doing every week: on an animal this size, a lump the size of a pea is a large lump.

LUMPS AND ANYTHING NEW

DATE	WHERE	VET
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

TAMING, A WEEK AT A TIME

Do not skip one

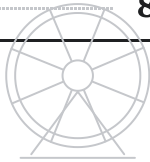
STEP	STARTED	THERE
Left alone to settle in, a week	_____	☐
Talking near the cage, every evening	_____	☐
A hand resting inside, not moving	_____	☐
Food taken from a flat palm	_____	☐
Walking onto the hand for food	_____	☐
Scooped up, both hands, low over a table	_____	☐

A bite is almost always a startled hamster

Woken up, grabbed from above, or a finger that smelled of dinner. It is not temper and it is not personal. Wash your hands before you reach in, say something first so they know you are there, and never take a hamster out of its nest to show somebody. Children sit on the floor with a hamster in their lap, or they do not hold it yet.

WHO MAY HOLD THIS HAMSTER

And how



While we are away.

Date _____

THE BASICS

Hamster _____ Dates _____

Us, and the best number _____

If you cannot reach us _____

Vet, and out-of-hours (page 2) _____

EVERY DAY, PLEASE Evening is best — they are up

☐ Tap the water bottle and watch a drop come out

☐ Yesterday's fresh food out, a little new food in

☐ Lift out the wet corner of bedding

☐ See the hamster awake and moving at least once

FEEDING Amounts, not "a bit"

WHAT	HOW MUCH	WHEN
------	----------	------

_____	_____	_____
-------	-------	-------

_____	_____	_____
-------	-------	-------

_____	_____	_____
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MEDICATION, IF ANY

WHAT	DOSE AND WHEN	GIVEN
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_____	_____	☐
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_____	_____	☐
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Please do not

Wake them to look at them, take them out, clean the whole cage, move the cage into another room, or open the lid with the door to the room open. And if they are curled up cold and stiff in a cold room, they may not have died — that is torpor, it happens when a room drops below about fifteen degrees, and it is a telephone call to the vet, not a bin bag.

WHERE EVERYTHING IS

WHAT	WHERE
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Food and treats	_____
-----------------	-------

Spare bedding	_____
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Sand	_____
------	-------

Cleaning things	_____
-----------------	-------

Carry box	_____
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Spare key	_____
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THE ROOM

Keep it at _____ Lights off by _____

MESSAGE US IF

Anything different.



Date _____

DATED, HOWEVER SMALL Two lines now beat memory

DATE	WHAT YOU NOTICED	TOLD VET
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

QUESTIONS FOR THE VET

What counts as worth writing down

Less on the wheel. A hoard that stops growing. Sleeping somewhere new, or out in the open. Drinking more. A wet chin. Fur thinning over the hips. Grams going down two weeks running. None of these is an emergency on the day, and all of them are the sort of thing a vet asks “how long has that been going on?” about.

GETTING OLD, WHICH HAPPENS QUICKLY

- ☐ Wheel swapped for one they can still get into
- ☐ Climbing taken out, ramps put in low
- ☐ Bedding still deep, but a shallower way in
- ☐ Food where they sleep, and something softer
- ☐ Weighed weekly rather than monthly

WHAT WE WOULD WANT FOR THEM

Two years is a short time and it goes faster at the end. Deciding in advance what you would and would not want to put a small animal through — and writing the vet’s number beside it — is a kindness to the person you will be on that day.